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Housewife Vloggers on YouTube and What the Internet Does to Women's Reproductive Labor

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1. Introduction

Every era has produced its own motifs and ideologies about being a housewife, shaped by the gendered ideals of its social and economic order. In Maoist China, where women's employment was the norm, the figure of the housewife was stigmatized.¹ By contrast, in post-war United States, 'career woman' became a derogatory term for white middle-class women² at a time when being a housewife was increasingly tied to the rise of household consumer goods. In interwar Norway, housewives were viewed as 'professionals' and urged to become independent leaders of the home, reflecting the progress women had made during industrialization³ but also signaling their return to domesticity. In post-liberalization India, the expansion of the formal service sector gave rise to the figure of the office-going woman,⁴ who combined paid work with the responsibilities of managing the household.

This essay is concerned with a new figure shaped by the era of the internet: the housewife vlogger. She is not merely a housewife but also a content producer for one of the world's largest tech corporations. She monetizes her housework, supports her family, and often introduces her children to the competitive world of content creation from an early age. She is part of an era where everyone—not just women—is expected to work and make money, where even children and pets are coopted into the project of monetization. Work is an extension of life, and success is increasingly measured by one's ability to convert life itself into income-generating content. In this logic, everything can become content, and life becomes the raw material for both consumption and monetization.

The phenomenon of housewife content creators lies at the intersection of commodification, the internet, women's work, and reproductive labor. As such, it serves as a powerful site for studying the interplay between these forces. This essay asks: What happens to women's work and reproductive labor under the regime of the internet or, more specifically, digital capitalism?

To answer his question, this essay draws on interviews with four women vloggers conducted between October and November 2024, alongside insights gathered from routinely watching housewife vlog channels on YouTube over four years. The monetization of their own housework represents a unique mode of commodification in the internet era, one that differs from other digital forms such as platform-mediated gig work or outsourced domestic work. This labor is performed in one's own home and encompasses the entirety of domestic life rather than being segmented into discrete gigs. Vlogging not only intensifies housewives' overall workload but also reconfigures the structural forces that underpin their housework.

1 Zheng Wang, "Gender, Employment and Women's Resistance," in *Chinese Society: Change, Conflict and Resistance*, ed. E. Perry and M. Selden, 162–86 (London: Routledge Curzon, 2003).

2 Betty Friedan, *The Feminine Mystique* (London: Penguin Classics, 2010).

3 Kari Melby, "The Housewife Ideology in Norway Between the Two World Wars," *Scandinavian Journal of History* 14, no. 3 (1989): 181–93, <https://doi.org/10.1080/03468758908579171>.

4 Smitha Radhakrishnan, "Professional Women, Good Families: Respectable Femininity and the Cultural Politics of a 'New' India," *Qualitative Sociology* 32 (2009): 195–212, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11133-009-9125->

No longer mandated solely by the sexual division of labor, their work becomes increasingly shaped by the imperatives of YouTube's algorithm. As housework becomes 'content', it detaches from its embeddedness in gendered household routines and is reorganized around platform incentives and audience demand.

The women vloggers in this study—successful, pragmatic, and business-minded—grapple with this new form of commodified labor. Their identities on YouTube are built through housework, but the same housework often appears out of sync with their success and aspirations. Media-savvy and ambitious, they recognize and navigate YouTube's hierarchies of big, medium, and small creators, and adapt their sense of self to where they land within them. The challenges they face, such as visibility, audience engagement, and sustainability, are shaped by their scale, reach, and longevity on the platform. Despite the opacity of algorithms and the increasingly saturated creator economy, these women persevere, sometimes attaching side hustles to their content work to stabilize income or expand reach.

Finally, this essay examines the complexities of why viewers are drawn to daily vlogs, and how relatability, while a key driver of viewership, becomes a trap that vloggers must build and uphold. As vlogs and their comment sections become sites for women viewers to reflect on their own domesticity, they also serve as spaces where feelings of envy, dissatisfaction, commiseration, and community are projected onto vloggers. In turn, vloggers are compelled to commodify ever more aspects of their lives, as long as the algorithm rewards such disclosures.

2. Who are the housewife vloggers?

This essay focuses on upper-middle-class women in India and draws from, and contributes to, scholarship on gender and the middle class. These women can afford childcare and domestic help but deploy this assistance strategically, balancing the need to preserve their identity as homemakers with the desire to avoid the drudgery of housework.⁵

These also have the economic flexibility to opt out of the formal labor market. Focusing on these women enables a singular focus on reproductive labor. Unlike lower-class women, such as farmers and domestic workers, whose paid and unpaid work exists on a continuum that makes it difficult to disentangle productive and reproductive labor, the subjects of this study have clearly defined reproductive roles that do not blend with other forms of labor. Put simply, middle-class housewives largely perform reproductive labor as housework in their own homes. This analytical focus also ensures that both the content being studied and its audience belong to the same socioeconomic category, allowing for a focused analysis of the phenomenon.

Securing interviews with these women vloggers, however, proved to be challenging. I contacted over 30 women vloggers via email, Instagram direct messages, and the comments section of their YouTube videos. Fewer than half responded, and only eight explicitly agreed to participate.

5 Nair, Gayatri, and Nila Ginger Hofman. "Middle-class Women and Domestic Work in India and the United States: Caste, Race and Patriarchy." *Sociological Bulletin* 71, no. 1 (2022): 24–40. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00380229211063157>

In many instances, vloggers would ‘like’ my comment on YouTube or Instagram and leave it at that, mirroring how they engage with audience reactions without entering into dialogue. The process revealed the extent to which their time is tightly managed.

Take, for instance, Manvi, a creator with over 100,000 subscribers who publishes videos twice a week and whose content I had been following for over four years. While she expressed willingness to participate after I contacted her by email and Instagram, she was unable to find time for an interview during my research period. Others who managed to make time did so over several days and in short durations.

The brief sketches of four housewife vloggers below represent varied motivations and experiences, and together illustrate the changing landscape of vlogging. Each case is unique and informs the analysis in important ways.

Kajal: From makeup tutorials to a family-focused empire

Kajal’s journey embodies the evolution of online content creation in India. She started her YouTube channel in 2015, documenting her life as a stay-at-home mother. Her early videos focused on beauty and makeup tutorials, demonstrating how mothers could prioritize self-care despite time constraints.

The 2016 rollout of the Reliance Jio mobile network, which provided free internet access at the time, dramatically expanded digital connectivity across India and led to a boom in YouTube viewership. This shift boosted Kajal’s channel, allowing her to earn a substantial income.

Capitalizing on this success, Kajal expanded her content portfolio by creating multiple channels focused on beauty and cooking, hiring other women as on-screen presenters while a dedicated team handled content planning, scripting, and editing. Her husband, an avid cook, also launched his own cooking channel, further diversifying their YouTube portfolio.

However, the landscape changed in 2020 with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic and the Indian government’s ban on TikTok. The migration of former TikTok creators and celebrities to YouTube led to increased competition. The pandemic also introduced operational challenges, forcing Kajal to manage her team remotely and adapt to limited content options during lockdowns. These factors, along with her relocation from Mumbai to Lucknow in 2021, led to a decline in viewership and earnings. Despite the contraction of her YouTube presence, Kajal continues to create content on her main channel and holds immense knowledge about vlogging.

She currently has over 683,000 subscribers on YouTube.

Poonam: Corporate employee strategically leveraging YouTube

Poonam was in a lucrative corporate job when she had her first child. Figuring out parenting involved a lot of Googling and online research, and Poonam thought it would be useful to share this knowledge with other mothers through YouTube videos. This was 2017, and she knew YouTube was helping people reach a wide audience and make money in the process.

Initially, Poonam treated her childcare and parenting videos as a side hustle but turned content creation into a full-time career during the Covid-19 pandemic. With schools closed and parents scrambling to keep their children engaged, she began receiving requests from parents for formal learning modules. This prompted Poonam to expand into creating educational material and launch an online learning platform. As her online presence solidified, her audience grew, motivating Poonam to quit her corporate job.

Actively avoiding daily vlogs, Poonam strives to strike a balance between sharing her personal life and producing generalized parenting content. Today, she uses her YouTube channel as a marketing tool for her educational products, aiming to convert her audience into a customer base. She sees content creation primarily as a sales channel, maintaining an active presence to reach new audiences at no cost. Her content includes home organization, recipes, family vlogs, and educational material.

She currently has over 39,100 subscribers on YouTube and earns revenue from ads, brand promotions, and her business producing educational material for parents.

Radhika: From wedding blogs to motherhood vlogs

Radhika found success on the internet even before YouTube. When she was about to get married in 2012, she quit her job as a fashion assistant because her workplace was too far from her in-laws' home. Bored and restless without work, she started a blog about her wedding, treating it as an extension of diary-keeping, a hobby she had maintained since childhood. The blog soon caught the attention of leading fashion and culture magazines such as Cosmopolitan, Femina, and Hindustan Times Brunch, many of which featured it on their platforms.

As Radhika outgrew writing about weddings, she did not want to lose her audience and turned to comedy videos on YouTube. This was when such content was gaining traction globally, with comedians like Lilly Singh, an Indian-Canadian YouTuber, becoming popular for humorous takes on personality archetypes and impersonations of immigrant parents. This style of content, rare in India at the time, resonated with Radhika. She saw an opportunity and segued into making comedy videos about weddings. These videos—with titles like “Types of People You Meet During an Arranged Marriage” and “Things People Say at Indian Weddings”—did well.

After the birth of her first child, Radhika's life revolved around motherhood. This transition was reflected in her YouTube content, as she gradually became one of the first family vloggers in India, documenting her parenting journey and daily life.

She currently has over 79,300 subscribers on YouTube.

Diksha: New-age vlogging, a family enterprise

Following her wedding in 2019, Diksha moved from Bihar to Florida, United States, with her husband. With no job or social life, she was already feeling isolated when the COVID-19 lockdowns made things worse. The reprieve she had looked forward to—visiting her family in India—was no longer an option, and there was little else to keep her occupied.

During this time, Diksha began exploring the idea of publishing YouTube videos, something she had considered when she first moved to the US. The platform, she thought, could help her achieve two things: build connections with others and give her family a way to stay updated on her life abroad. Her travels within the US also seemed content-worthy.

She began by uploading travel videos, recipes, and clips showing how she was replicating aspects of her life in India while living in the US. These included videos titled “Saawan (monsoon/rainy season) in America”, “Playing Cricket in America”, and “Chhatt Puja in USA”. She quickly learned that her viewers were less interested in travel videos, no matter how exotic the destination, and more drawn to content about how she managed her life at home. That insight prompted Diksha to begin vlogging about her daily routine as a housewife.

Her journey marks a shift in the creator economy and how the average person engages with it. From Radhika, who for years kept her YouTube channel hidden from most of her family for fear of judgment or backlash, to Diksha, who draws wide support from hers, the acceptance of YouTube vlogging as a viable career has come a long way. Diksha’s family, including her parents-in-law, husband and son, are deeply invested in her vlogging journey. They not only follow her content but also divide tasks among themselves, treating it as a joint effort.

Diksha currently has over 21,700 subscribers on YouTube. However, her channel is not yet eligible for ad revenue and remains unmonetized.

3. Commodification of reproductive labor: Why do housewife vloggers stand out?

The commodification effect of digital platforms on reproductive labor has been widely studied. The gig economy isolates specific tasks from the broader context of routinized domestic work and transforms them into marketized services mediated by platforms. In other words, housework is broken down into discrete jobs or ‘gigs’—cleaning a room, cooking a meal, or providing fixed hours of childcare—whose supply and demand are governed by algorithmic systems.

Similarly, theories of digital labor highlight how activities once considered non-work are now absorbed into systems of value creation. Concepts such as prosumption,⁶ consumption labor, playbor,⁷ signal the collapse of boundaries between leisure and labor on the internet, which functions simultaneously as a factory and a playground.

6 Axel Bruns, *Blogs, Wikipedia, Second Life, and Beyond: From Production to Produsage* (New York: Peter Lang, 2008).

7 Trebor Scholz, ed., *Digital Labor: The Internet as Playground and Factory*, 1st ed. (New York: Routledge, 2013).

In parallel, analyses of how the internet commodifies everyday life⁸ and privacy⁹ identify data as the underlying commodity. Marxist feminist frameworks use the concept of reproductive labor to interpret digital labor, extending the unpaid yet essential nature of domestic work to digital activities. The figure of the digital housewife¹⁰ extends the characteristics of women's housework—crucial but unpaid—to digital labor, drawing attention to non-waged work that remains critical to the functioning of capitalism. This concept has since been used¹¹ to examine the operations of various digital platforms.

However, the reverse inquiry—how digital labor interacts with and transforms reproductive labor—remains underexplored. In particular, little attention has been paid to how the internet's commodification affects women's housework. Research on women's vlogging has focused on areas such as community¹² and identity building,¹³ parenting practices,¹⁴ religious messaging,¹⁵ and neoliberal self-fashioning.^{16,17} While feminist media studies have engaged with YouTube as a phenomena, it has not asked what it means to perform housework for the internet. Abidin's work, which identifies the home as the locus of content creation,¹⁸ describes how the rhythms of daily life become a mode of class performance in vlogs but does not explore the implications of this performance for the laboring lives of content creators. This is a critical gap because the commodification of housework through vlogging differs from other platform-based labor models in significant ways.

First, vlogging captures the simultaneous performance of productive and reproductive labor. This differs from the double-burden paradigm, in which women balance paid work outside the home with unpaid work inside. In the case of vlogging, housework becomes the site of both income generation and care work.

8 Göran Bolin, "Media Use and the Extended Commodification of the Lifeworld," in *Technologies of Labour and the Politics of Contradiction*, ed. P. Bilić, J. Primorac, and B. Valtýsson (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2018), https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-76279-1_13

9 Sebastian Sevignani, "The Commodification of Privacy on the Internet," *Science & Public Policy* 40, no. 6 (2013): 733–39.

10 Kylie Jarrett, *Feminism, Labour and Digital Media: The Digital Housewife* (New York: Routledge, 2016).

11 Kathleen Wauthier, Andrew Fisher, and Radhika Gajjala, "Digital Hierarchies of Laboring Subjects," in *The Routledge Companion to Media and Class*, 203–12 (New York: Routledge, 2019).

12 Julie Smith, "Sharing Intimate Moments on YouTube: Women Who Vlog and Their Sense of Community, Friendship and Privacy," n.d.

13 Hanwool Choe, "The Presentation of Self via Everyday Vlogging: Analyzing Everyday Vlogs of Korean Expatriates," *Discourse, Context & Media* 59 (2024): 100784.

14 Umit Kennedy, *Becoming on YouTube: Exploring the Automedial Identities and Narratives of Australian Mummy Vlogging* (2019).

15 Amber Rose Snedden, "'Keeping Up': A Study of 'Mommy Vlogging' and Its Influence on Mothers' Practice of Intensive Mothering," PhD diss., The Chicago School of Professional Psychology, 2024, ProQuest Dissertations & Theses (30992904).

16 Chih-Ping Chen, "Forming Digital Self and Parasocial Relationships on YouTube," *Journal of Consumer Culture* 16, no. 1 (2014): 232–54.

17 Yasmin Ibrahim, "Accounting the 'Self': From Diarization to Life Vlogs," *Convergence* 27, no. 2 (2021): 330–42.

18 Crystal Abidin, "Hanging Out at Home as a Lifestyle: YouTube Home Tour Vlogs in East Asia," in *The Routledge Companion to Media and Class*, 122–131 (New York: Routledge, 2019).

Second, vlogging entails the constant presence of the platform in the vlogger's life. Seen most clearly in the 'morning-to-evening routine' of mom videos that are popular among viewers, the full spectrum of reproductive activity becomes content, appropriable by the platform and its monetization logic.

Third, unlike gig work or domestic work, where commodified services are performed in others' homes, this labor is carried out by women in their own homes, for their own families. Yet it is no less commodified.

When asked how vlogging has changed their experience of housework, the women interviewed for this study emphasized that commodification was not limited to the monetization of domestic labor through YouTube but was felt more acutely as an intensification of labor. Longer workdays had become the norm. The tasks required to record, edit, and upload videos extended their working hours, as every household chore slowed down to accommodate the demands of producing content.

Vlogging also led to a reallocation of housework and a reshaping of domestic priorities. Housework, women vloggers explained, was no longer guided solely by personal and domestic logics but increasingly structured around the incentives of the digital platform. This shift required them to perform a version of 'being a housewife' shaped by algorithmic and audience expectations. It not only contradicted their personal preferences but also differed from their pre-YouTube realities.

Both outcomes—longer workdays and succumbing to platform logics of how to be a housewife—are commodified effects of vlogging on housework, explored below through the experiences of vloggers.

3.1. Doing housework for money and fame: I was being forced to do housework to make YouTube videos

The most common outcome of vlogging is the elongation of the workday. Choreographing daily routines for vlogs slows down each task to accommodate the demands of content creation. "A lot of it feels like a stage performance of your actual routine, right? So, it slows down the process of your life," Poonam shares. Challenging the notion that anyone can pick up a camera and become a vlogger, she highlights how the supposedly low entry barrier on YouTube means little in the face of the consistent effort required to create and upload content. "Editing also takes a lot of time, and even for routine videos and vlogs, you're filming, and then you must cut out pieces, because you're filming for a whole 10 hours together, right? And then out of that, you're supposed to pick and choose, and that's why I think on YouTube, despite it being a low-entry-barrier space, you do not see as many people consistently putting out content," Poonam adds.

Diksha finds that completing tasks now takes her twice as long:

“A task that you would normally finish in five minutes, while shooting, takes a full 10-12 minutes because you’re turning the camera on and off in between, changing angles. When I am cooking, if I pour oil in the wok, I’m not going to be able to take that shot again if I mess it up, right? So, I must be extra careful. I go and double-check to see if the frame is right or not, if the lighting is right.”

Other reproductive roles, like childcare, also expand. Poonam explains:

“If you are recording a video where your child doesn’t have to be in the video, then you either have to wait for your child to go to sleep and then record videos, which is not at all practical because by the end of the evening, you are also tired, and if you’re doing it in the middle of the day, then you would want somebody to watch over your kids, so the need for help with taking care of children has increased.”

Vlogging not only expands housework but also reshapes how women perform the role of housewife. Radhika, for instance, dislikes cooking but recognizes that the audience wants to watch her cook. She admits, “I can cook, but I don’t enjoy it. On YouTube, I felt that the cooking videos always did really well. This led to times when I had to cook because I was making the video, even though I would not have cooked otherwise.”

During festivals like Diwali, she makes elaborate preparations she would not normally undertake. In her household, ordering in is the norm when guests visit, but when vlogging, she feels compelled to cook and serve homemade dishes to cater to her audience. She says:

“[F]or YouTube, I had to search for special recipes. It would take almost half a day because I would be shooting five to six recipes in the same day. So, I had to arrange all those resources, make all those things, then, you know, lay them out properly. It’s a lot of time that goes. And then, of course, a lot of energy that goes. Because normally, if a guest is visiting my house, I would not be the one cooking at all.”

These pressures became more pronounced when Radhika transitioned from being a housewife to running a business. With little time left for housework, she had to rely on hired help. “Doing household work or cooking just didn’t make sense in terms of what my life was and, for me to just do it for YouTube, it was just senseless,” she says. Despite the shifts in her personal life, she remained acutely aware “that’s the content the audience likes. That’s the content the audience enjoys,” which led her to continue performing housework for the sake of her videos.

These implicit audience expectations resemble conventional gender roles and divisions of labor. However, it may be inaccurate to label this as a straightforward re-entrenchment of patriarchy. YouTube vlogging represents a new-age phenomenon whose outcomes differ from the conventional effects of patriarchy. Women do housework to generate content that garners views and algorithmic traction. Housework, when subsumed by platform logic, undermines the sexual division of labor: it is performed to become commercially viable on the platform, not to uphold the division of labor at home.

Combined with the complex and varied reasons women audiences consume this content, it becomes apparent that class anxieties, and not patriarchal notions alone, shape viewers' desire to see their favorite creators remain within the mundanities of domestic life that characterize middle-class womanhood. Improved class status renders creators unrelatable and draws backlash from women audiences. These findings are discussed in detail in a later section.

It is, however, unsurprising that women vloggers often become financially independent, ambitious, and pragmatic as they find success on YouTube. This dynamic particularly resonates with older women audiences who have spent their lives doing unpaid housework. Kajal notes that her older viewers, aged roughly 45–60, connect with her content on a deeper level. They see her as a source of inspiration and as a representation of opportunities they missed, often expressing regret for not being able to build their careers because of a lack of support and family obligations. These women find vicarious satisfaction in Kajal's success, viewing her achievements as a testament to the possibilities that exist for women bound by household responsibilities.

As some audiences find solace in watching younger women build careers while performing domestic roles, overall reactions to these videos remain varied and complex. The key takeaway from the narratives of these women is that the YouTube algorithm becomes the primary determinant of what they reveal of their lives. Whether through shopping hauls or daily cooking videos, the primary objective remains to appease the algorithm rather than to perform roles set by their families.

These algorithmic mandates may intersect with or diverge from traditional patriarchal expectations, but vloggers experience them as platform logics. Moving away from housework as a gendered role, however, does not mean freedom from all constraints. Being a vlogger presents its own challenges, shaped by YouTube's competitive, hierarchical environment and its notoriously opaque algorithm.

3.2. Working the platform: YouTube's hierarchy, algorithms, and the uneven struggles of women vloggers

A vlogger's challenges vary depending on two related factors: the size of the audience and the length of time she has been active on the platform. These factors also shape how she and her family perceive YouTube. While size is indicated by metrics such as subscriber count and views, and is generally seen as a marker of success, the length of activity refers both to the creator's personal experience over time and to the broader public knowledge of YouTube at the time she began vlogging. Newer vloggers can benefit from the accumulated learnings about the platform that older ones had to discover through trial and error.

Vloggers with larger channels are more likely to be invited to YouTube events, have access to a YouTube manager, and identify more readily as a YouTuber. In contrast, new and smaller creators often experience anxiety about their progress, though many remain optimistic that consistent effort will eventually earn them recognition and entry into the club of successful creators. For instance, the energy that Diksha invests in growing her channel exemplifies aspirational labor¹⁹ a concept that captures how creators work hard for extended periods before seeing any financial return. At the time of being interviewed, Diksha expressed panic at the thought of missing uploads due to an upcoming move. Posting twice or thrice a week felt insufficient, and she repeatedly expressed disappointment in herself. Making videos, she said, was “a habit”. With 21,000 subscribers and under 3,000 watch hours, Diksha was not yet eligible for the YouTube Partner Program, which enables creators to monetize their channel and make money from ads. Her anxiety about consistency, widely seen as the only reliable path to success on YouTube, was evident.

There are also mid-level creators, some of whom are less preoccupied with defining their relationship with the platform. Poonam, for instance, views YouTube as a tool:

“I don’t relate directly to being on YouTube or working on YouTube because my scale is limited. I know there are creators who get called to the YouTube Creator Summit who have a stronger connection with YouTube. At my level, it’s more about what functionalities and audience YouTube offers me. For instance, I like the format of YouTube. I prefer long-format videos, so I prefer that. As per my understanding, most of the small and mid-level YouTubers or content creators are like that.”

Driven by pragmatism, Poonam focuses on using YouTube to establish her business, which further distances her from identifying the platform as her primary workplace. With a large enough following to sustain a business, YouTube remains a means to an end. “This is not my primary job. So, people also don’t kind of relate to me as ‘Oh, her career is a YouTube channel,’” she explains. Though relatively new to the platform, she has been strategic in building a sustainable source of side income, likely learning from the experiences of earlier creators.

The struggles faced by women vloggers are also shaped by the size and maturity of their channels. Ironically, YouTube profits the most from smaller accounts that have not yet qualified for ad revenue. Diksha highlighted this issue while discussing her frustrations as a new creator. YouTube shares 55 percent of each advertising dollar with monetized creators, which is more than platforms like Meta’s Instagram. However, for smaller non-monetized channels, ads still run, and YouTube keeps all the revenue. While a single small channel might not generate substantial revenue, the combined output of thousands of aspiring creators adds up significantly in YouTube’s favor.

19 Brooke Erin Duffy, (Not) Getting Paid to Do What You Love: Gender, Social Media, and Aspirational Work (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2017).

Diksha is acutely aware of how YouTube profits off her, and this awareness influences how she views her role in this ecosystem, even as a small creator:

“My channel is not monetized. So that’s very beneficial for YouTube. Channels that are not monetized, YouTube earns from the ads they display.”

Even Kajal, who has seen success on YouTube, has her own resentments. She has noticed that her earnings from the platform have declined consistently each year. She explains:

“YouTube’s earnings go down every year [by] almost 20 percent. If you earned 20 lakh this year per month and you earn consistently, like you work regularly, so 20 lakh, 18 lakh, 19 lakh, like that, the amount keeps fluctuating. But by January, it gets deducted by 20 percent. Then next year you will get 20 percent less, and then next year another 20 percent.”

Beyond declining income, there is growing fatigue with YouTube’s algorithm. Kajal expressed frustration with its complexity and the constant changes that make it difficult to predict what content will perform well. Despite attending workshops and trying various strategies, she has been unable to decode it and feels that much of the available guidance is unreliable.

“With the algorithm here, I have tried every way, thinking this will work, that will work. But till today, I have not been able to crack it. I have also attended many workshops on what the algorithm is, a lot of workshops are by YouTube too. They said you have to change the name of the file, then you have to upload at this specific time, at this minute, and this second. That’s the level to which people explain the algorithm in a workshop.”

This lack of a clear roadmap for success contributes to a broader perception that being a YouTuber is akin to running a business, primarily because one is on their own, without guidance or supervision. After years of trial and error and missed opportunities, Radhika now sees YouTube as a solo enterprise, something she wishes she had realized earlier.

“In case of a job, the boss oversees you. If you don’t do your job, you’ll get scolded for it, or somebody will tell you you’re not doing your job. But if you don’t do your job when you’re YouTubing, and you don’t create a video, then it’s your loss. So, in that sense, it is a business.”

What took Radhika years to understand is already clear to Diksha. “It’s like a startup, where you can succeed if you keep at it. [...] I don’t know how long it will take to grow, but I do consider my channel a startup,” she asserts.

Another experience that distinguishes older and newer vloggers is how their families perceive their YouTube work. Radhika, who began a decade ago, had to explain her online activities to her family. In contrast, Diksha's family has been supportive from the start. She considers her channel a "joint venture" with her husband. "He is completely involved in my channel. It's our channel, it's not just my channel. I think earlier he used to do 90 percent of the work, and I would do 10 percent," she says.

Poonam and Diksha represent a new generation of YouTube content creators who are strategically leveraging the advantages of being creators in a highly competitive and saturated landscape. Their families are well acquainted with the potential of content creation. Kajal and Radhika, on the other hand, represent the pioneers whose success coincided with YouTube's boom in India. They and their families had to discover YouTube's potential in real time. While size and maturity determine the experience of women vloggers, women also view their relationship with YouTube through these parameters. It is harder for women to see themselves as YouTubers when their direct interaction with platform representatives is limited. However, there is also a critical acceptance of the realities of the landscape, evident in women's attempts to attach side businesses to their channels and to critique YouTube for profiting from them even when they make no money.

3.3. The relatability trap: Audience expectations, class anxieties, and the pressure of daily vlogs

Daily vlogs, characterized by their frequency (uploaded daily) and monotony (focused on daily routines), perform exceptionally well on YouTube. "The more you offer, the more people watch, and the more they watch, the more they'll keep wanting to [watch]," says Diksha. Once an audience becomes invested in a creator's life, they want to see more of it. "The one thing that I've learned is that the audience loves watching you do the same thing again and again and again [...] they like to watch me wake up, make breakfast, prepare school lunch, take my kids to school, the same thing every day," Radhika says. Poonam describes it as a long-term investment: "Watching vlogs is a continuous process, where over a period of one month, two months, you become invested in someone's life, and that's the basic human tendency, right?"

However, even creators who have successfully used this formula admit that it is ultimately unsustainable. While audiences may crave repetitive domestic routines, vloggers often struggle to maintain them, especially as success on YouTube brings changes to their lives and lifestyles. Kajal and Radhika share how their audiences reacted negatively when they tried to shift away from housework-related content.

When Radhika started a business following her YouTube success, she struggled to keep her viewers engaged:

"I tried to shift my content to showing what it's like to run a business, but my audience didn't like it. My views fell drastically, and they haven't recovered to the same level. It was very difficult to recover from that. They want to see me do household work, the same things repeatedly. For me, it was the complete opposite. I was working in an office, but they wanted to see me cook food for my kids."

Kajal too tried something new, only to be pulled back by audience disapproval:

“I got bored of making the same routine videos, so I would take my videographer and go to the market. But whenever I did this, viewers didn't like it. They just want to see my life and how I am living at home. Even if I am making dal-chawal, they want to see that.”

Both Radhika and Kajal say they feel trapped by the expectation of living and presenting the same life day after day. Unable to keep up, they now face dwindling views and engagement.

Relatability, women vloggers note, is the primary reason driving the audience's insistence on routine and repetition. Radhika and Poonam expressed similar views. According to Radhika, “Social media has become a huge part of where we connect to people through mediums like vlogs and families' vlogs, and then watch them on a daily basis to see how their life is progressing.” Poonam added, “Routine vlogs will do better with whoever is your exact mirror audience.” These observations align with existing research, which highlights relatability^{20 21} as the key reason audiences enjoy watching women replay their everyday lives on the internet.

Yet, even as vlogs provide a space to discuss the burdens of housework and the struggles of married life, the relationship of relatability between the vlogger and her audience remains fraught. The inherently confessional nature of the internet,²² exemplified in daily vlogs, invites reactions that span empathy, envy, schadenfreude, and catharsis.

Class anxieties surface when viewers feel that a creator's lifestyle exceeds their own. Comments like “You show off a lot” were commonly left on Kajal's vlogs. If her vlogs showed perceived indulgences such as frequent restaurant outings, for instance, the audience reaction was swift: “You have money, that's why you are doing this.” She further shares, “If I ate out thrice a week, I would have to listen to these taunts.” This criticism was especially painful, as Kajal has always enjoyed going out, eating out, and traveling.

Paradoxically, this antagonistic relationship often increases viewer engagement. Kajal's vlogs about conflicts with her domestic worker became unexpectedly popular, as audiences turned their backlash against her into support for the worker:

“They love the house-helper tragedies. Viewers want to know if my house help has run away again. They would leave comments like ‘You're not nice to them, that's why she left you. She was good, you were not a good person.’”

20 Guiquan He, Koen Leurs, and Yuru Li, “Researching Motherhood in the Age of Short Videos: Stay-at-Home Mothers in China Performing Labor on Douyin,” *Media and Communication* 10, no. 3 (2022): 273–89, <https://doi.org/10.17645/mac.v10i3.5510>

21 Earvin Charles Cabalquinto and Cheryll Ruth Soriano, “‘Hey, I Like Ur Videos. Super Relate!’ Locating Sisterhood in a Postcolonial Intimate Public on YouTube,” *Information, Communication & Society* 23, no. 6 (2020): 892–907, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2020.1751864>

22 Theresa Sauter, “‘What's on Your Mind?’ Writing on Facebook as a Tool for Self-Formation,” *New Media & Society* 16, no. 5 (2014): 823–39, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444813495160>

This “meanness of the audience”, as Kajal puts it, also extends into deeply personal territory. When her husband quit his job, even her most loyal subscribers speculated that he was becoming dependent on her YouTube income. Others repeatedly pointed out the harsh tone of her mother-in-law toward her. At other times, they accused her of neglecting her mother-in-law.

Such scrutiny reveals the flip side of relatability. In a Girardian²³ sense, housewife vloggers serve as role models who are familiar enough to be relatable, yet distant enough in their success to incite envy. Viewers appear keen to see these women falter, to witness the downfall of successful vloggers, and to watch them experience the drudgery of housework, especially when success has made their lives appear more privileged. Kajal’s audience, for instance, closely follows how she copes when her domestic worker is absent, likely drawn both by curiosity and by the desire to see her humbled.

Beyond the soothing effect of mundanities and the reliable nature of routines depicted in vlogs, there exists a complicated relationship between the vlogger and her audience, one that is fraught with anxieties. At times, these anxieties stem from class inequality, as viewers direct their frustrations toward women whose lives reflect a higher socioeconomic status, thereby signaling and constructing their own shared class identity. At other times, they emerge from deep reflection on gendered experiences, enabled by a balance of distance from and proximity to the vlogger’s life. This dynamic allows for the externalization and projection of realities that weigh heavily on perhaps every woman’s life—marital conflict, cruelty, grief, resentment—creating a space for release and catharsis.

Internet-savvy and content-driven, vloggers play into these curiosities and anxieties. Vlogs by the channel ‘Pakistani Mom in the USA’, who quit vlogging sometime last year, routinely conveyed the pain of being overworked and underappreciated by her husband. While it was evident in her videos that this was true, complaining about her husband was also a recurring theme in the voice-over narration. He had highly specific tastes and frequently demanded preparations reminiscent of his mother’s cooking from childhood or flavors that replicated dishes from a popular restaurant.

Yet, amid the tightly shot montages that carefully avoid revealing more than intended, the oversharing of personal dissatisfaction stood out. In the comments section of her video titled “Aaj husband ki demands ne bohat thaka diya” (Today, the husband’s demands really tired me out), I found confirmation from her of what works on the platform. A commenter asked, “Your titles are always so sad, but there’s not much information about that in your videos. Please don’t mind, I love your videos.” To this, the vlogger has replied, “Yehi chalta hai (This is what works).”

To summarize, housewife vloggers become trapped in a cycle of showing the same mundane routines, as audiences demand that they stay relatable; departing from this turns them into subjects of scrutiny and envy. However, seasoned vloggers learn to play into these dynamics, sustaining an ecosystem that thrives on a delicate balance of relatability, mundanity, and projection of audience anxieties.

23 Critical Legal Thinking, “Mimetic Desire & the Scapegoat: Notes on the Thought of René Girard,” Critical Legal Thinking, September 4, 2023, <https://criticallegalthinking.com/2023/09/04/mimetic-desire-the-scapegoat-notes-on-the-thought-of-rene-girard/>

4. Conclusion

This essay examined the unique phenomenon of housewife vloggers who, for the first time in history, are able to earn an income for doing housework within their own homes. Their simultaneous engagement in reproductive and productive labor through housework vlogs offers a compelling site to study the interactions of the internet, commodification, and women's labor. It broadens the conceptual boundaries of what the domestic sphere can be in the future and reinforces Haraway's argument regarding the inadequacy of binary frameworks in understanding contemporary forms of labor.

Interviews with four housewife vloggers reveal that YouTube's algorithm remains opaque and, when combined with audience preference, produces expectations of women performing domestic roles. Regardless of their personal preferences and changing life circumstances, vloggers are compelled to cook and perform other forms of housework in an effort to retain viewer engagement. In doing so, they expose their lives and relationships to public scrutiny. However, attributing this solely to a re-entrenchment of the sexual division of labor may be insufficient. The algorithm represents a new-age force that produces outcomes distinct from conventional patriarchal expectations. Women vloggers emerge not only as subjects of constraint but also as successful, ambitious, pragmatic, and independent creators navigating a highly competitive landscape. Creators with larger channels who have found success, smaller vloggers who struggle to be noticed in a sea of content creators, and those with mid-sized followings together constitute the hierarchy that defines YouTube and shapes how vloggers perceive themselves and their labor.

For women viewers, a fragile relationship of relatability with the vloggers is frequently threatened by underlying class anxieties, especially when creators display markers of success. Nevertheless, vlogs serve as a crucial space for reflection on women's lives, producing complex interactions and feedback loops. Finally, this essay captured the changing landscape of the creator economy and its perception among families. From being an odd hobby to a promising career that the entire family can support and participate in, it is evident that content creation is an important part of what the future of work may look like.

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